

LSD mm September 23, 1954

Preliminary LSD memo

MARGARET MEAD
Box 101 Folder 5

OFFICE FILE

SUBJECT FILE

1954

1 ~~xxxxxx~~ Problems of Consciousness Princeton 1954
2 presented Caligor to Problems of Consciousness, Abrahamson interested,
3 he had asked me how to get candidates for experimentation from low
4 income groups the year before. I suggested Father Divine's angels,
5 Only other knowledge of the drug was a brief conversation with Arnold Meadow
6 before he got his dissertation. He said it was a drug which induced a
7 psychosis. Abrahamson telephoned and proposed collaboration with Caligor.
8 June 6, 1954 Met Ralph Blum, through Cathy, told he had been working on Russian
9 films, extraordinary speed of communication, he claimed due to LSD. Got interested
10 in possibility of it's being a speed short cut.
11 June 8, left for San F. Anthropology and Education conference, presented speed pt.
12 June 14, stayed with M. Erickson, read Huxley Doors of Perception, very bored with
13 pts. Talked over drugs and his Cooper speed pt. Betty Alice produced Life article.
14 June 16, lunch with Booth, casual discussion, he mentioned my earlier refusal to
15 take Mescal, said I'd said it while we were going somewhere in a taxi, must have
16 have been early 40's. Then it turned out he HAD taken mescal in experiments in
17 Germany, and thought he owed much of his insight to it. Began to develop idea of
18 who should and who shouldn't take it. Discussed what evidence he had.
19 Cocktails with Leo Rosten. HE mentioned he was having an article on HOW IT FEELS TO
20 BE INSANE presenting it as insight giving to sane doctors who could now experience
21 what their patients experienced. I mentioned possibility of uncontrolled use,
22 Ericksons said people had been writing Huxley.
23 ~~xxxxxx~~
24 August 16 presented Toronto paper, mentioning speed and drugs in discussion, and
25 also mentioned it at lunch with Hargreaves and FFS
26 Read Edith's paper for CRM book (MM and MW) and became more interested in polarization
27 between actuality adjustment and phantasy. a point I'd made to her earlier in working
28 over some stage of her manuscript.
29 September 15, first session with Abrahamson, his two young men, Murrey E. Jarvok and
30 Conan Kornetsky (US PH had been at Lexington working with drugs, interested in pain,
1 Caligor also went. Had dinner, talked, saw Siamese fighting fish under drugs, heard
2 a record in which a subject (a chemist working with Abrahamson,) had felt he was a
3 a "bump on a log". Learned its non-addictive character. Asked if I'd take it,
4 said not sure. Explored "truth aspects", and decided it is not a "truth drug".
5 September 18, wrote Bali chapter and after rereading all my old stuff on the drama and
6 arts decided Balinese held to actually by participation in the theatrical process.
7 New possibility for LDS - away from mysticism and escape.
8 Dreams during this week, two new characteristics, objects in
9 dreams appeared to have a liquid quality, surviving in brightness
10 of surface, which after
11 Sept. 19... Conversation with Richard L. Davis on models for open ended systems, walls
12 and ceiling "go by each other", Mondrian goes around corners,
13 Sept. 20 luncheon conversation with RM telling her about Mondrian model and suggesting
14 possibility of needing to turn a corner (of canvas) or road, if we are to have
15 built in openness that is built into the system and not just into the culture.
16 She then recalled her "turned corners" in report on French, using Levi Strauss
17 RCC after her return from Haiti, 1950(?). Could do no more with point.
18 Sept. 20 second conversation with Richard, more about Mies van der Rohe, (architect who
19 did I.I.T. in Chicago, corners have a piece out, giving the flying past each
20 each other effect) this was mentioned last night) and more about Renaissance building
21 being a closed system, done on 3 which gives a center as compared with 2-4-8-.
22 Told him some bits about Aspects of form, Symmetry, etc.
23 Dreams now included extensions of any object out into space,
24 using liquidness as a way of pulling the end of table out into

coming to the conclusion that I would try the drug, especially after reading Abrahamson's third paper, a case of removing fear of homosex. in one therapeutic 4 hour session.

September 22. Second LDS session, present as before plus two female subjects, Schwartz - old subject, and Weltman (one before 25). and John Eberhardt as an interested observer. (Had been talking to Jarvik about it. I asked him). Both given Caligors before, then had dinner, and did Caligor's again with same O.I. drawing (this was suggested to me by Abrahamson after Sept.22, I called Caligor, he agreed). Then Caligor got Koretsky to a TAT type interrogation on them. (This I haven't seen yet) Saw the drawing before, though Schwartz, potentially sick, paranoid and stiff, Weltman probably a dancer, or interested in body rhythms, and not sick. No comments from anyone.

During evening both girls around (I had dinner early with Abrahamson, his sec. who in a state of giggles from another drug, her husband and Koretsky. Jarvik, the 2 subjects Caligor and the Polish named chemist had dinner later. Orig. plan had been one placebo, but changed to be sure enough of interest, with Eberhardt coming too, so we had one experienced subject, and one with second increased dose.

Schwartz - giggling uncontrollably and meaningfully, short bursts, no depth, reported sense of focussing on one person then others would blend into a circle, seemed far away (? Jarvik), yes, when in groups had felt this way, distanced, not really listening. Stiffness in face, made gestures of opening mouth, stretching face oddly. When questioned eyes would slew about. Reported drug was going away, was back. Reported no affect to drug, had it sometimes. Questioned me about my trip, had been an anthro major, said difficult to concentrate, but did.

Weltman, graceful dark little German Jewish girl, neurological secretary in a studying to me an opera singer with an Italian who feels everything starts with soul, never mentions body, soul must grow and voice come out. Wants to BE this, but wonders if it's wrong to try to be a dead and gone culture, feels teacher is right "soul is a little material thing for the voice to cling to, likes her job but feels that the people given shock aren't really psychotic, talks to them when acting as assistant and feels contact with them. Maybe the doctors wouldn't like this. Wants to be a singer, but would not sing under LSD. Is concerned with keeping control, will keep it, brought up rigid German, her parents now know better, look what happened, she likes Eastern European Jews. Gestures become more Jewish after excursions away in talking. Asked about Caligor, no disturbance of precision" I drew well, I never draw, isn't it a pity - we often confuse ends and means... I get so interested in other things during the way. (All this in an interview out in the hall, alone with me, had wanted to get out, felt nauseated (no fear of vomiting), stiffness in chest, (she thought what everyone had boys said not), dryness of throat, stiff neck, misery, fear of laughing, had laughed a lot before...xxhxx

3 conversations with her, first in group people sitting around, she reported no distortion of vision, auditory distortion, own voice too loud, people distant, harmonization of voices not attended to, sense of need for more control.

right after

1 Then second Caligor given, and in this interval I took John in for a chat about
 2 a proposal to Have Francis Hsu work at Rockland, we went on to Talk about Manus,
 3 Weltman came in, wanted to ask me about music, which she had started just
 4 as I went in with John. We went on to a conversation about Manus, what was
 5 their music - I said couldn't really discuss, but did Boola song, by this time
 6 Schwartz had joined us and when questioned, sang boola song. Group now "eltman,
 7 Schwartz Caligor, Kornetsky (? Jarvok). ~~Shaxaxka~~ Then I said Manus beautiful
 8 in action described a canoe crew, paddle tiller, 3 men to sail, she watched my
 9 my hands. Then asked me to speak some Manus, and when I translated, began to
 10 pick out words, picked I, and speak (I said Jo pa ku panangau Manus), and
 11 said she picked them because like Italian and Portugese), then I did more sentence
 12 and she withdrew from game, co ldn't place any. Then we talked ~~xxxx~~ about
 13 PE, here she was very cautious, withdrew from intuitive guessing. Then asked
 14 by Jarvok, any differences, reported slowness of perception gap between word
 15 image, normally would have seen canoe at once when I talked, I said she had
 16 watched my hands: I then asked what kind of sail, she said oh, like an American
 17 sail(started to sketch in order thre sides American sail O and said very
 18 suddenly - \$x "Four sides". and added " not white, more like colour of your
 19 dress" (pale brown. Argument with secretart's husband who was now in room,
 20 about sails, all were 4 sided, but later after hall interview, showed she thought
 21 normally of three sides, but returned stubbornly to a non-existent type of
 22 four sided American sail.
 23 Periodically, all through, leaned over with her head on her knees hands over
 24 head- to keep from starting to la gh and control nausea- Said she wanted to go
 25 home - this was just an introspective report. Disliked it very much, preoccupied
 26 with contro;. Told me in hall that she had drawn waterfront tupe and a sailor.
 27 (ADD to sequence. luhnch with elicia Saxe and her story of patieny - truck
 28 driver homosex. and his pos ural and voice identification with his mother when
 29 come out of swimming. FS did it oy oy, breathing, and I could run right on
 30 with the associations - what I did for you, my breast, etc.)
 31 End of session about 11(had begun at 6, and as I was dead tired at five I
 32 gone to LJ's and had two stiff Scotches before dinner, just picked me up.)
 33 Discussed next plan, Caligor's would be blind evaluated, studied, then
 34 back to Abrahmson group, there would be written up.
 35 Home w th Caligor, taxi and coffe at 51st street, he very jubilant over
 37 confirmation of his diagnostic points, differentiating psychsis, thinks the
 38 does not produce psychoses but only exaggerates main tendencies towards
 39 control, disintegration, etc. This agrees with Abrahmsaon. Caligor interested
 40 in widening horizons, changing therapy so available, changing society,
 41 thinks theory has outrstipped practice, any therapy if good is good therapy,
 42 need the level of crafstmanship, espec ally prognosis for therapy by tests,
 43 said our society getting sicker, I argued no, more troubles - broken heart,
 44 relihion, politics, etc being so claffied.

ah's

Good we in
 4-9
 RESERVED

LSD - mm Sept. 25, 1954

1 letter to R. Blum yesterday.
2 Note that I am tending to label any new or good ideas as associated
3 with the project because I am watching my dreams and my dreams
4 are being theoretically fertile at the moment.
5 Last two days dreams having been playing elusively with closed and
6 open systems, just detached, I'd wake and say "that's why it's
7 hard to get rid of the bones. Suddenly realized that the pt about
8 reincarnation, appearance of ancestors in ccs etc. is that
9 the problem of closed and open systems is of course the dead.
10 Iatmul, if people didn't die the villages would be choked with
11 faeces. The threat to the open endedness of the Manus system is
12 the graveyard, and the reason there are always ancestral ghosts
13 in ccs is the point of extreme transition, standing between old and
14 new, past and future, then you have overcrowding of ghosts, and or
15 bones - (Bali is always obsessed by the balance pt, what to do
16 with the body, and this explains WHY that getting rid of the body
17 is so crucial, it's the break in the closed system - unaccounted
18 for matter)... Soviet put you in the RED WALL before you break up
19 the system and it has to kill you - storage pts in the system.
20 Part of the growth point of Christianity as Protestantism was
21 breaking the med. closed system of unborn souls, and heaven which
22 at any moment could have closed completely, and in a sense had.
23 This to be investigated.
24 Pt about the turn in the read, (see earlier notes on Sept. 20
25 and 21) is to introduce the sense of an open system into the
26 very closed system of the French. This can be done in the arts
27 but less easily in the sciences, because of the personal
28 uniqueness of each artistic production, each performance etc.
29 Same function performed by "deurong terang" in Bali

Good use in
Ch. 4 + 9
RESERVED